

Wealth, War, and Mortality: Assessing “Rich Man’s War, But a Poor Man’s Fight” in the U.S. Civil War

Joan Barceló

Perry J. Carter

Jeffrey L. Jensen

Leonid Peisakhin

January 23, 2026

New York University Abu Dhabi

- Long-standing debate over what motivates people to fight – and *die* – in civil wars
- Those with the most at stake have the most incentive to fight...
 - ... but also the most options to avoid fighting, *even if they enlist*.
- In this paper we address this question in the context of the US Civil War using:
 - Newly linked individual-level census records (1860–1870)
 - Confederate enlistment and rank data
- Main findings:
 - Slave-owners more likely to enlist...
 - ...but also less likely to die than non-slave-owning Southern men

Motivation and Background

Motivating Question

Core question

In civil wars, are economic elites more or less likely to put themselves at risk – not only by enlisting, but by actually fighting?

- Long-standing aphorism in the U.S. South:
“A rich man’s war, but a poor man’s fight.”
- Widely invoked in accounts of the Confederate war effort
- But until recently, we lacked data to rigorously test who actually died

Revisiting Greed and Grievance

- Elites might avoid combat
 - Higher opportunity costs
 - Ability to pay for substitutes, exemptions, or safer roles

Revisiting Greed and Grievance

- Elites might avoid combat
 - Higher opportunity costs
 - Ability to pay for substitutes, exemptions, or safer roles
- Alternative view: Wealth increases the stakes of conflict
 - Owners of valuable assets (land, slaves, businesses) have more to lose
 - Strong incentives to fight to defend those assets

Revisiting Greed and Grievance

- Elites might avoid combat
 - Higher opportunity costs
 - Ability to pay for substitutes, exemptions, or safer roles
- Alternative view: Wealth increases the stakes of conflict
 - Owners of valuable assets (land, slaves, businesses) have more to lose
 - Strong incentives to fight to defend those assets
- Existing work often uses enlistment as the main outcome
 - But enlistment and mortality need not co-vary

Why the U.S. Civil War?

- The Confederacy seceded to preserve slavery
 - The direct economic beneficiaries were slave-owning households
- Slave-ownership was highly unequal: roughly 10% of families owned about 90% of all enslaved people
- Slave-owners enjoyed dramatically higher wealth
- Atypical civil war: symmetric regular warfare with universal conscription.



The Puzzle

- Recent work finds (Hall, Huff and Kuriwaki, 2019) slave-owners were more likely to enlist in the Confederate Army
- This has been interpreted as evidence that the war was *not* “a poor man’s fight”
- But enlistment does not tell us:
 - Who faced front-line combat?
 - Who had access to safer roles and better treatment?
 - Who actually died?
- Our contribution: move beyond enlistment to mortality

Literature: Who fights in civil wars?

- Grievances and deprivation as drivers of political violence (Gurr, 1970; Collier and Hoeffler, 2004; Fearon and Laitin, 2003; Humphreys and Weinstein, 2008; Berman et al., 2011)
- Organization, resources, and social base of armed force (Weinstein, 2006; Kalyvas, 2006; Boone, 2014; Rozenas, Talibova and Zhukov, 2024).
- Debates around Confederate participation motivations in the US Civil War (McPherson, 1984, 1997; Hall, Huff and Kuriwaki, 2019).

Data and Research Design

Data: Linked Confederate-Era Censuses

- Population: native-born White males in the 11 Confederate states
- Age range in 1860: military-age cohort (5–44 in 1860)
- Key idea:
 - Link individuals in the 1860 census to the 1870 census
 - Compare match rates by slave-ownership status of their family in 1860
- Outcome:
 - **Matched in 1870** $\Rightarrow$ survived the war period
 - **Not matched** $\Rightarrow$ likely died (but may have emigrated / otherwise missing)

Census Records

Page No. 115

SCHEDULE 1.—Free Inhabitants in 5th Ward Rochester **in the County of** Monroe **State**
of New York **enumerated by me, on the** 27th **day of** June **1880.** James Quotley **Ass't Marshal**
Post Office Rochester

Dwelling-houses— numbered in the order of visitation.	Families numbered in the order of visitation.	The name of every person whose usual place of abode on the first day of June, 1880, was in this family.	DESCRIPTION.			Profession, Occupation, or Trade of each person, male and female, over 15 years of age.	VALUE OF ESTATE OWNED.		Place of Birth, Naming the State, Territory, or Country.	Married within the year.	Attended School within the year.	Persons over 20 yrs of age who cannot read & write.	Whether deaf and dumb, blind, insane, idiotic, pauper, or convict.
			Age.	Sex.	White, black, or color.		Value of Real Estate.	Value of Personal Estate.					
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14

Linkage Strategy

- Challenge: names may change spelling; some records lost; families move
- We implement a semi-supervised matching procedure:
 - Standardize names and basic demographics
 - Generate an initial match using FastLink (Bayesian matching)
 - Refine match with machine-learning model
- Result:
 - Successfully match over 60% of eligible individuals across censuses
 - Substantial improvement over earlier attempts at Civil War-era linkages
- Extensive checks suggest no strong bias toward matching slave-owners

Measuring Mortality by Slave-Ownership Status

- We compare (log) risk ratios of:
 - Match rates for men from slave-owning families
 - Match rates for men from non-slave-owning families
- Interpretation: lower match rate $\Rightarrow$ higher probability of death
- We treat this as an estimate of *relative war-time mortality* by slave-ownership status

Mechanism Data: Confederate Enlistments and Ranks

- To understand mechanisms, we link 1860 men to:
 - National Park Service roster of Confederate Army personnel
- From these data we observe:
 - Whether an individual enlisted at all
 - The type of service and rank (e.g. officer, enlisted, home guard)
- This allows us to ask:
 - Did slave-owners end up in safer roles?
 - Among those who fought, who died at higher rates?

(CONFEDERATE.)

C	37	Va.
---	----	-----

George R. Cowan
Capt., Col., 37 Reg't Virginia Inf.

Appears on
Company Muster Roll
of the organization named above,
for Sept & Oct, 1862
dated Dec 11, 1862
Enlisted:
When May 2, 1861
Where
By whom Capt. Hunt
Period 3 yrs
Last paid:
By whom Capt. Cole
To what time Aug 31, 1861
Present or absent Absent
Remarks: Wounded at
Beads Run Aug. 9
on forehead

The 37th Regiment Virginia Infantry was accepted into the service of the Confederate States July 1, 1861, and reorganized April 22, 1862. Companies G and I were consolidated under Captain Bussey after the October 31, 1862, muster, but such company appears to have been mustered separately most of the members of the regiment were captured in May, 1864, and the remnants of the companies were later assigned to Companies H and K.

Book mark:

Main Results

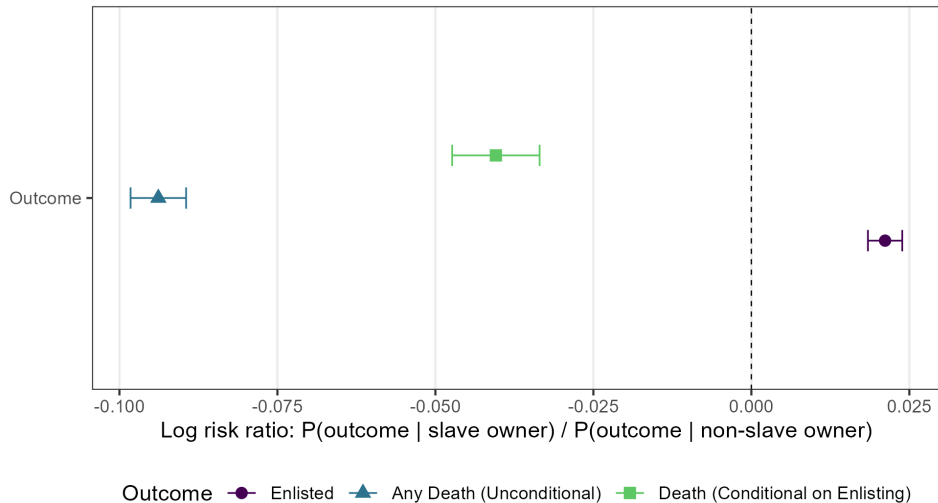
Main Result: Survival Advantage for Slave-Owners

- Using linked census records, we estimate:
 - Men from slave-owning families are notably *more likely* to be found in 1870
 - The gap is on the order of four percentage points in survival
 - But they are also more likely to enlist in the Confederate army!
- This implies:
 - Higher mortality among non-slave-owners...

Main Result: Survival Advantage for Slave-Owners

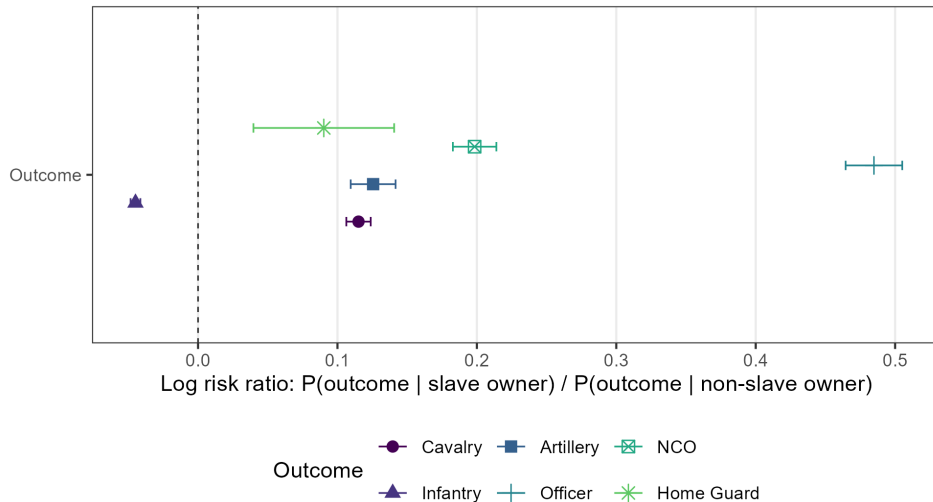
- Using linked census records, we estimate:
 - Men from slave-owning families are notably *more likely* to be found in 1870
 - The gap is on the order of four percentage points in survival
 - But they are also more likely to enlist in the Confederate army!
- This implies:
 - Higher mortality among non-slave-owners...
 - ... even though slave-owners had the largest stake in preserving slavery

Death Risk Ratios by Slave-Ownership Status

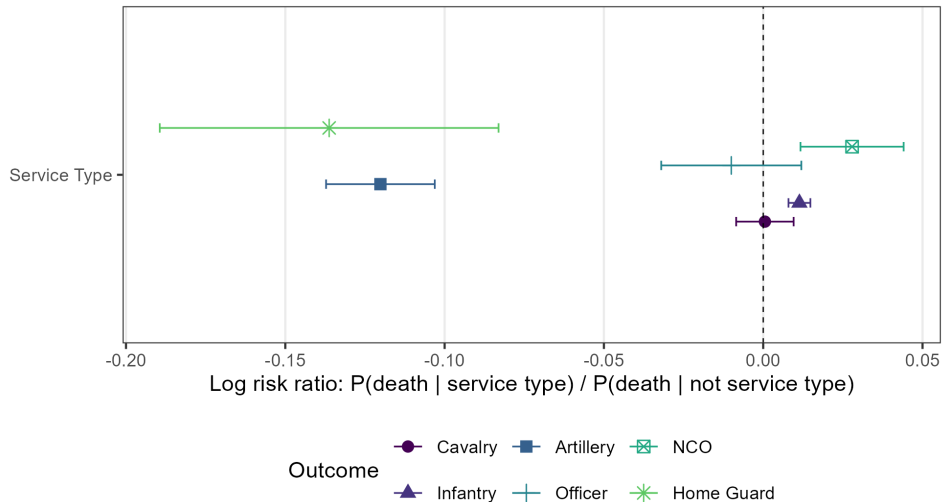


Mechanisms

Enlistment Patterns by Slave-Ownership Status



Death Risk by Service Type

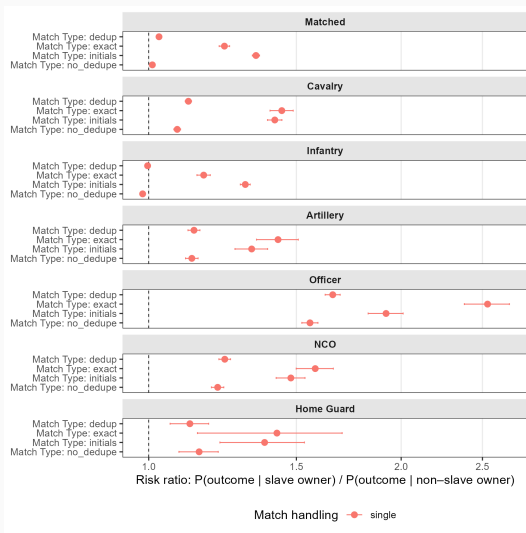


Putting It Together

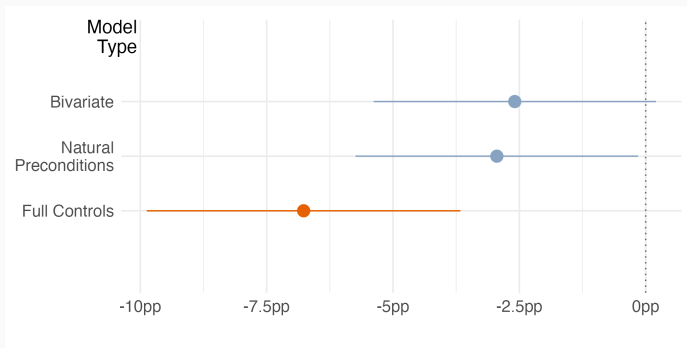
- Step 1: Slave-owners enlist at higher rates than non-slave-owners
- Step 2: Conditional on enlisting, slave-owners:
 - Are more likely to become officers or join home guard units
 - Are less likely to serve as front-line enlisted soldiers
- Step 3: These roles carry lower mortality risk
- Result: Slave-owners “fight” more in terms of enlistment, but face lower risk of death than poorer non-slave-owners

Robustness and Alternative Evidence

Adjusting for Covariates/Match Types

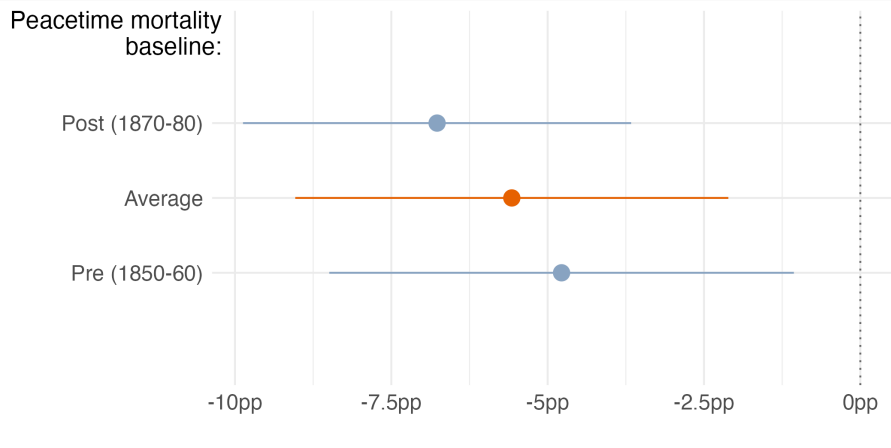


Alternative Mortality Proxies



- We also examine county-level excess mortality measures
- Counties with higher slave-ownership rates tend to have fewer war-related deaths among military-age white men

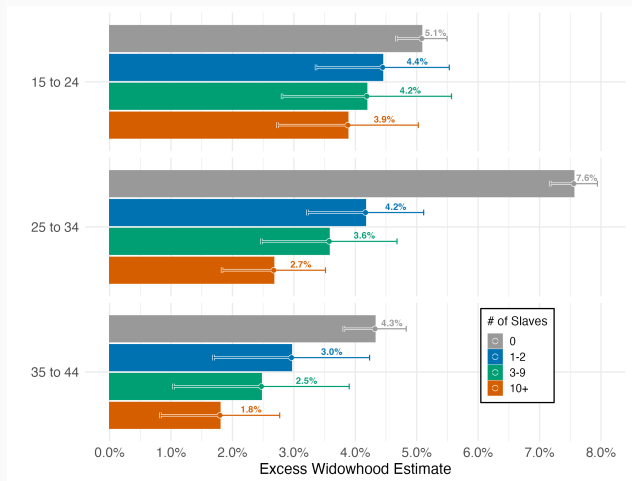
Robustness to Peacetime Mortality Estimation Procedure



Widowhood Evidence I

- We construct a proxy for mortality among married men:
 - Compare widowhood rates by pre-war slaveholding status
- Wives from non-slave-owning or small-slaveholding households are more likely to be widowed by 1870
- Key advantage: does not rely on name matching

Widowhood Evidence II



Interpretation and Implications

Revisiting “Rich Man’s War, Poor Man’s Fight”

- Our evidence shows:
 - Slave-owners fought more *on paper* (enlistment)
 - But non-slave-owners died more
- In mortality terms, the war was indeed:
A rich man’s war, but a poor man’s fight.

Broader Implications for Conflict Studies

- Wealth matters not only for whether elites join the war effort, but also for:
 - The positions they occupy
 - Their ability to shield themselves from risk
- Enlistment is an incomplete measure of sacrifice
 - We need to track roles, exposure, and mortality
- In highly unequal societies, elites can both:
 - Mobilize the poor to fight,
 - And simultaneously minimize their own exposure to death

Limitations and Scope Conditions

- Inference relies on census linkage:
 - Non-matches may reflect emigration or non-response, not only death
- Mechanism evidence comes from imperfect records
- The US Civil War is a somewhat idiosyncratic case; unclear how our findings might generalize to modern asymmetric or irregular civil wars.
- Nonetheless, multiple independent data sources point in the same direction

- In this paper, we focus on the simple question of who fought in the civil war.
- However, linked censuses also provide an opportunity to study the legacies of exposure to conflict both as combatants and non-combatants with rich micro-data.
- **In progress:** study the consequences of irregular warfare and civilian casualties in the border states on downstream political outcomes.

Thank You

Questions?

References

- Berman, Eli, Michael Callen, Joseph H Felter and Jacob N Shapiro. 2011. “Do working men rebel? Insurgency and unemployment in Afghanistan, Iraq, and the Philippines.” *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 55(4):496–528.
- Boone, Catherine. 2014. *Property and political order in Africa: Land rights and the structure of politics*. Cambridge University Press.
- Collier, Paul and Anke Hoeffler. 2004. “Greed and Grievance in Civil War.” *Oxford Economic Papers* 56(4):563–595.
URL: <https://academic.oup.com/oep/article/56/4/563/2361696>
- Fearon, James D and David D Laitin. 2003. “Ethnicity, insurgency, and civil war.” *American Political Science Review* 97(1):75–90.

References ii

- Gurr, Ted Robert. 1970. *Why Men Rebel*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
- Hall, Andrew B, Connor Huff and Shiro Kuriwaki. 2019. "Wealth, slaveownership, and fighting for the Confederacy: An empirical study of the American Civil War." *American Political Science Review* 113(3):658–673.
- Humphreys, Macartan and Jeremy M Weinstein. 2008. "Who fights? The determinants of participation in civil war." *American Journal of Political Science* 52(2):436–455.
- Kalyvas, Stathis N. 2006. *The logic of violence in civil war*. Cambridge University Press.
- McPherson, James M. 1984. "Ordeal by fire: the Civil War and Reconstruction."
- McPherson, James M. 1997. *For cause and comrades: Why men fought in the Civil War*. Oxford University Press.
- Rozenas, Arturas, Roya Talibova and Yuri M Zhukov. 2024. "Fighting for tyranny: State repression and combat motivation." *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics* 16(3):44–75.
- Weinstein, Jeremy M. 2006. *Inside rebellion: The politics of insurgent violence*. Cambridge University Press.